ACME'S POLICY GOVERNANCE TOOLKIT

As ACME matured its policy governance process, it realized that effective governance relies as much on tooling as on procedures. Five complementary tools—ADRs, version control, CI/CD pipelines, and automated log analysis—support the company's approach to managing the policy lifecycle.

Architectural decision records (ADRs)

Every policy starts with a decision: what problem it addresses and why the organization selected a particular approach. ACME documents these rationales in ADRs, simple documents that record context, alternatives, decisions, and outcomes. Each policy file includes a comment referencing its ADR ID, making it easy for anyone reviewing the policy to trace it back directly to the recorded rationale. A helpful introduction to ADRs, with templates and examples, can be found in Joel Henderson's Architecture Decision Record repository on GitHub (https://github.com/joelparkerhenderson/architecture-decision-record).

Version control

Policies are stored and managed within the same Git-based repositories as configuration and service definitions. Version control offers a complete history of changes, author attribution, and peer review through pull requests. This process guarantees that no policy can be added, modified, or retired without explicit approval from an authorized reviewer. Version metadata and comments become part of the governance record.

CI/CD pipelines

Once a policy is merged, ACME's continuous integration and delivery pipelines automatically lint, validate, and test it before deployment to the PAP. The pipelines ensure quality and consistency, making sure policies are syntactically correct, logically consistent, and compatible with existing decision flows. Automated testing prevents regressions and lowers the operational risk of changes.